In February 1945, he was posted as the commanding officer of a rail-based petroleum sub-depot at Samasata, about 20 miles from Bahawalpur, a princely state in the Punjab. Being the only officer, he also doubled as the station commander of the small military set-up there, with a few junior commissioned officers and soldiers under his command. It was almost like a one-man-and-a dog team. As my mother was expecting me, her first child, great love and care was lavished on her by my father. A box of 'bedana' (seedless) grapes from Chaman, near Quetta, that my dad arranged for her at that time was something that she remembered all her life. It was in this small, dusty and remote military cantonment that I was born on 17 September 1945. My mother had a forceps delivery, and both she and I survived, in an era in which there were many deaths during childbirth.

While the Allies were winning the war in 1945, colonial India's domestic political scene was witnessing turbulent times. The British had realized that India could no longer remain their crown jewel: the sun was setting over the empire, and the future of the subcontinent had to be decided soon. There was a growing feeling amongst the people of India that independence was round the corner. At the same time, rumours that India was being partitioned were spreading like wildfire. In this wartime scenario, the Indian Army, particularly the Indian officers, junior commissioned officers and other ranks, faced great uncertainty. Once the war ended, this feeling got accentuated even more. The sad prospect of serving in different armies once Hindustan was split into two nations was not easy to digest. It was ironical as armymen, irrespective of whether they were Hindus, Muslims, Sikhs or Christians, never thought of themselves as anything but Hindustanis. But at this juncture of history, the officers and men had become a confused and perplexed lot. Time was running out and the soldiers had to decide quickly whether they wanted to serve in the Indian or Pakistani army!

Many people in the Punjab had a flicker of hope till the very end that they might not be uprooted from their land, home and hearth. Such sentiments were understandable. However, a great catastrophe befell the Indian subcontinent on 3 June 1947, when the